words left unsaid

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words left unsaid

by that_one_sleep_paralysis_demon

Summary

And what a pair they made, one silenced and one blinded. One afraid to speak and the other desperately clinging onto the last shreds of their naivety.

The pretense was long since up and here they were, still stuck as unwilling actors in the biggest shit show of their lives.

Or,

Mydei's point of view over the years

Notes

Okay so I did pull through and write out Mydei's point of view. Originally, the main story was supposed to have both Mydei's and Phainon's povs but that would have been too complicated. So I thought I'd write something smaller just to fill in some gaps growing pains had.

I do suggest reading the previous part before this for proper context.

Again, here are the warnings:
Extreme homophobia
Suicide
Religious fear

so please take caution if you aren't comfortable with these topics

See the end of the work for more notes

Excerpt 1 from the letter

I don't know how to start this, so all I can offer you is a lackluster introduction. Not that you will ever read this given your lack of responses to all my others. So consider this my final attempt, since everything else has fallen on deaf ears. What we had is damaged beyond salvation, I'm afraid. You left and never responded and I'm in Kremnos, still trying to reach you. Tell me, what did I do wrong? How can I get you back? I say this as if you were ever mine to begin with, so forgive my foolish ramblings.

You and I can never be and I am acutely aware of that. There is something horribly wrong with me for loving a man and I have come to terms with it. I know I shouldn't covet you, I know I shouldn't have thought of you like that and I never should have been in love with you. But here I am and I'm sorry.

My words will never be enough to convey my feelings, but it is the only vice I have left. So take it as you will— loathe me all you want.

Phainon, your name carries unimaginable beauty to it. We ought to start having favourite words because your name would be mine. It reminds me of glory. It reminds me of warmth. You are exactly that to me— summer skies and bright suns. At first, I swore I was sated by being near you. Then, I dreamed of you kissing me and I fear I have not been the same since.

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Eighteen years ago

Phainon had only ever told him good things about the temple— how grand it was and how everyone there was so nice. He complained that he had no one to chat with, so here Mydei was, trailing after the old lady next door with a crocodile skin handbag. It rattled unceremoniously with every step she took.

Mydei could see the marble columns of the temple. It was exactly how Phainon described it — standing tall, the view of Kephale's back against the horizon. The old lady was already at

the foot of the temple. Mydei scrambled to catch up. That's when a figure clad in pure white descended upon him. Nikador believed dead warriors were clad in white when they died.

"Are you a fallen warrior?" Mydei asked.

The man's face curled upward in disgust.

"Scum are not welcome upon these hallowed halls."

Mydei was six; he didn't need to know what each word meant to understand he was not welcome here. But his mother taught him to be brave. She told him to stand up against people that didn't treat him right. To be ready to protect himself and the people he loved.

"But isn't everyone allowed here?" Mydei clenched his fists.

The man in white raised a hand to strike. Mydei had never though a person could be capable of so much hate before this day.

"Stop! He's just a kid!" Phainon's father blocked the man's hand before it landed on Mydei.

Like a coward, Mydei ran. And he didn't stop until he was far away.

Phainon was here. How could he think these people were kind? What did they do to Phainon if this is what they did to him?

Mydei didn't have to wait long for the response because that very evening, the light in Phainon's eyes had dimmed. Phainon was a source of constant light— with unending lists of things to say. His eyes sparkled when he talked, when he smiled. The sparkle was replaced with fear. His face was drawn tight and his shoulders shook slightly.

"She was screaming. They looked happy." He whispered softly before his mother picked him up in her arms and took him home.

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Seventeen years ago

"Which one of us do you think would be Sherlock?" Mydei asked Lydia as they watched Phainon's retreating back.

Lydia raised an eyebrow. "Still on that?"

"C'mon, who do you think would be Sherlock?" Mydei insisted.

She just laughed, running a hand through her hair. "That's for you to judge, I'm afraid."

Mydei sighed heavily. He needed to settle this debate once and for all; Phainon was already getting on his nerves.

"Would it make you happy if I told you Phainon was Sherlock?"

"How? *I'm* smarter than him. I'm better at fighting too—" That part was a lie, Mydei had no clue who was better at fighting, "— I should be Sherlock!"

"Competitive much?" Lydia was just joking. Mydei sheepishly looked away.

She continued, "I think it doesn't matter. I think it matters more that you have a Sherlock or a Watson. A lot of people would do anything for a close companion like that."

Phainon was everyone's friend, but only best friends with Mydei. He was the only one who knew everything about Phainon— how he was still scared of the dark when he claimed he'd outgrown it, how he loved rainy days.

Mydei would be lying if he said that didn't make him feel special.

"Hold on." Lydia stopped by her front door, leaning against it, "Aren't you supposed to be going home too? It's already six thirty."

"My dad's supposed to be picking me up. He's taking us to a restaurant in the next town."

Lydia gestured to her house. "Want cookies?"

Mydei nodded rapidly, "if that's not a problem."

"Don't be silly." Lydia dismissed him with a light scoff, "Of course it isn't. You could barge into my house and raid my fridge if you wanted to."

"But would you be mad if I did that?" Mydei took a seat at her dinner table as she dug through her pantry.

Setting the box down, Lydia ruffled his hair affectionately. "There's no need to be a little gentleman. Why don't you be more free like Phainon?"

"He's immature." Mydei pouted.

"He's a kid. So are you."

Mydei hadn't really thought of it that way. Yes, he always liked how outgoing Phainon was. He just didn't feel any need to be like that. His parents would want him to be a good kid. That's what he'd be.

Night fell like a carpet and still no sign of his father. When the doorbell rang, it was his mother instead. She held his hand the entire walk home. When he asked her where Eurypon was, her face hardened for the fraction of a second.

"He couldn't make it." She said.

Mydei bit his tongue. He wasn't going to complain, he knew how busy his father was. He hadn't seen his father in weeks now.

"I'm taking you there tomorrow night, okay? Just you and me." Gorgo swung his hand playfully. Mydei smiled back at her.

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One year ago- before he saw him again

He wondered how Phainon was doing more than he'd like to admit. His heart lurched violently each time he thought he saw Phainon's hair. Spun around whenever he thought he heard his voice. Waited for letters that never came. Instinctively looked for him in crowds and then cursed at himself for being so hung up on a guy— but it wasn't just a guy. It was Phainon.

He never did get to know who'd be Sherlock and who'd be Watson. They argued about it years, all conclusions fruitless. He'd be anything, really, Sherlock, Watson, the victim— anything Phainon wanted him to be.

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Sixteen years ago

At eight, something changed. He wasn't entirely sure what it could be, but sometimes it was nearly impossible to take his eyes off Phainon. His heart raced unnaturally fast when Phainon grabbed his hand when they played. He'd count down the minutes until he could see Phainon again. A wiser man would have called those feelings the beginning of young love.

But weren't those feelings reserved only for a man and a woman? Then he saw how Lydia looked at her roommate and understood why people eyed them warily.

Mydei tried to squash his feelings like a bug. Time and time again, he'd convince himself it was normal to to have his face turn crimson when Phainon smiled at him. He *didn't* like Phainon. He *didn't* have a crush on him. It wasn't possible for boys to like boys. End of story. He still wanted to beat Phainon at everything. He still wanted to be first in their races and win their little fights. Surely he wouldn't be so competitive if he actually *liked* him.

And the more he reasoned with himself, the unsteadier the ground felt.

He later learned what happened to people like them, but at eight , he was still blissfully blind to it all. What he would have done in his later years to get that innocence back.

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Excerpt 2 from the letter

You have changed me. If I could begin to list all the things about me that were caused by your existence, I'd be here for a very, very long time. Someone once told me we are nothing but a mosaic of every person we have ever loved, I'd say you are the cerulean blue of the water and the sky, the ochre of the sun, the crimson hues of the sun's rays.

Honestly, fuck you. Phainon, fuck you and your gorgeous blue eyes and gorgeous smile. Fuck you for what you made me bring upon myself. I have never been able to look at another and think I could ever get over you. See, you are impossible to move on from. You were so much, you were so *different* and so *you* that I knew I'd never find another like you. No one could hope to be all that you were and I hate you for that. And it's in these times I regret knowing you to begin with. Maybe then I would've fallen in love with a woman instead.

Your lips were the first ones I kissed. The first and the last. Why did you have to glance my way, dear sun, why did you let me know what it felt like to have you if only for a few minutes? I'll spend the rest of my life replaying those minutes. I'm an addict who'll keep chasing that. I will grow old and all I will want is you. They'd call this devotion, a sigil of everlasting love, if only it was holy and pure in their eyes.

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Thirteen years ago

He now knew what happened to those people. They'd disappear or, as Phainon said, jump off the cliff into the watery depths below. How painful and cruel must the world be to them that they find solace in the frosty embrace of the tide. The people around felt less human the more he heard about the temple's actions. They felt like puppets on strings, bowing to the whims of the priests. They were monsters. The same people who'd do anything for their flesh and blood would clap as they were punished. Like all that love never existed.

They were at the moor that day he realised what his own future could look like. Perceptive, sharp and clever— those traits failed him in recognising his own raging feelings.

He knew how the other boys described liking girls as. A flighty feeling, like a little baby bird. Nervous jitters and shaky hands. And wasn't that exactly what he felt when Phainon laughed hysterically, rolling in the mud?

Mydei then decided he would tell jokes all his life for Phainon to laugh like that again. Mydei's knees felt shaky. He slowly lowered himself to the ground, still disbelieving. That lightness was now a heaviness pressing against his chest. His heart sunk and sunk until it could sink no further.

No.

No. He begged, *please not me. I'm not like those people. I'm not sick in the head. I didn't want to feel this way.*

He was just Mydei, Gorgo's son and Phainon's best friend. He wasn't wrong in the way a lifetime of prayer or punishment couldn't fix.

"What if I told you I'm a bad person?" Mydei blurted out.

Phainon tilted his head to the side. He propped himself up, scooting close to Mydei."But you're not?"

If only he knew. If only. Mydei knew that if he had even the slightest clue of what Mydei felt, he'd be far, far away from him. He'd stop being friends with him. He'd eye him strangely.

"Say that I am. Okay, say that I am a horrible, horrible person. What would you say to that?"

"You'll never be a bad person." Phainon said firmly.

"Even if I am something so bad the temple would condemn?"

"Come on, Mydei." Phainon bumped his shoulder, "You're just overthinking things. I know you'll never be something like that."

Phainon never did say how *he* would react to Mydei being a terrible person and that just about confirmed his worst fears.

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First, he hated Phainon for doing this to him, for making his traitorous mind think of such sinful things. Then, he hated himself for being the way he was, turning the daggers into himself. Finally, he closed his mouth like the words could slip out of him and cast his eyes down. He was best forgotten by all.

And even then, Phainon didn't leave. He once lashed out and called him a leech and some other things in an effort to drive him away from himself, as if distance would stop his feelings. Phainon punched him in retaliation. Once they were done fighting, he held out his hand. Mydei took it. Phainon wasn't going anywhere.

He'd considered telling his mother once or twice. If there was anyone on this planet who wouldn't hate him for being that way, it would be her. But each time, the words stuck themselves in his throat like chewing gum. Bland, tasteless, worming their way down his esophagus, constricting his lungs.

Each time, he came up with new excuses for why he was steadily becoming more skittish. Why he seemed mad all the time. He wasn't angry, he was scared. Scared that the truth of who he was was branded over his skin, like a close look at him could reveal it all.

Life never seemed the same once he came to terms with his future.

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Eleven years ago

It was a passing comment— a passing cruelty about Phainon. Mydei didn't even remember what it was years later, just that it was heinous enough for him to stop dead in his tracks and see red. His eyes burned, not out of impending tears, but from the sheer force of rage.

"Say that again." Mydei hissed, stalking up to Hyperion. He decided he despised that unkind tilt to his lips. That scornful, superior gaze. He wanted to wipe it clean off his face.

He scoffed, "I said that Phainon's a lowlife. Who does he think he is— thinking everyone's his friend? My Ma said he's the type to like *men*. Be careful or he'll like you too."

Mydei had to stop himself from flinching when Hyperion said the last part. It had no right to hit so close to home.

"Take that back." Mydei snapped, balling his fists up. The people surrounding Hyperion backed up slowly. They were clearly smarter than him, choosing not to invoke Mydei's wrath upon themselves.

"What are you, his guard dog?"

Mydei kicked him in the shin first. Hyperion staggered to the ground, writhing in pain.

"You—" He hissed,hands scrabbling at Mydei's ankles in a feeble attempt to drag him down too. Mydei stepped on his fingers in retaliation. Hyperion let out a pathetic noise, yanking his fingers out. Breathing heavily, he got back up. Mydei readied himself.

Hyperion hit back, fists flying wildly.

"How dare you?" Mydei spat, wincing as Hyperion's fist made contact with his jaw.

"I can say whatever I want to! Phainon's *weird* and that's that!" Hyperion said with the air of someone who was used to getting whatever he wanted in life. The air of someone never truly afraid before.

His mother told him to only fight when it was absolutely necessary— and nothing had ever been this urgent. Somehow, he knew that he wouldn't have reacted as violently if Hyperion had been slandering Mydei himself.

But Phainon? The boy with the laughter of a thousand tinkling wind chimes? The boy with eyes more brilliant than the ocean could ever be? The boy who brought warmth to every room he was in? No amount of times he hit Hyperion seemed enough. He deserved worse. What was his mother teaching him? What was this town teaching him? How could someone hate what could only be described as the brilliant sun in human form?

"Say that about him again and I will kill you." Mydei said quietly.

Hyperion faltered for the first time. He let out an incredulous, disbelieving laugh. The longer Mydei stayed silent, the more he began to realise that wasn't an empty threat. In theory, Mydei could. He was a far better fighter. His father owned a rising business. He had the potential to be that vicious.

"You— you wouldn't."

"I want to." Mydei replied plainly.

Hyperion looked years younger, walls down, terror so pure it was childlike.

Mydei grabbed him by the collar, wrenching him forward "Get out. Get out of my sight."

Pure, animal fear was written over that cocky face. Mydei bared his teeth in a maniacal grin. If he thought Phainon was weird, Mydei was worse. He'd rather have those rumors directed at himself. After all, none of them would be rumors. They'd be the truth. He was born with the wrong mind. Impure, unholy, a threat. Everything they'd say would be the truth. *He* was the type to like men. Not Phainon, *him*.

Look, he wanted to call out, *I'm the one you should despise.*

Hyperion moved out at some point. Bags packed, house sold. Some said he begged and threatened his parents to get him out. He refused to show his face, saying there was an insane person out there to kill him.

Eurypon was back from one of his business trips when he stormed into Mydei's room.

"Did you try to kill that boy?"

"No." Mydei replied. He had no way of knowing how his father would react; he was an unpredictable storm.

"Fine."

The door swung shut.

Gorgo got to know too; she simply asked him if it was for a good cause. Mydei nodded and that was that.

Mydei should have felt more guilt for his actions, but whatever search for remorse he had turned up empty. Phainon didn't question him either. He believed him as naturally as breathing. If he murdered someone someday, would Phainon still believe in him?

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Ten years ago

Mydei saw his descent before anyone else did. Phainon no longer spoke of the temple with wide- eyed adoration. The reverence in his gaze was replaced by something hollow. He spoke of the temple with an undercurrent of hatred. Mydei couldn't pinpoint when that happened, but all he knew was that one day, Phainon was disillusioned from it all. He reckoned even Phainon didn't know what he was starting to become.

"They killed him. Beck, I mean." Phainon said simply. This was the first time he'd talked about their upperclassman's death. It was a big deal when it first happened— the boy's mother's agonised wails that woke everyone up. Gorgo had been walking by and had been the first person to respond.

(*That night, she had dropped her sweater onto the couch and collapsed onto it, rubbing her eyes tiredly. She looked older than she was, having to take care of her house, job and child all*

at once. The weariness had etched permanent lines onto her face, but she was still the most powerful person Mydei had ever known.

"Mydeimos, don't you ever do that to me." She said quietly after Mydei brought her a cup of tea.)

Mydei swallowed. Stones lodged themselves in his stomach. He knew— he'd always known.

"I know." Mydei replied, voice hoarse.

"His parents can't grieve, no one remembers him fondly—" Phainon let out a frustrated noise, raking his hands through his hair, "—I can't even—"

He exhaled sharply, straightening his shoulders. Mydei whipped his head around to see some elders walked past with their canes clacking against the pavement. They pretended like they weren't listening, but in a place like this, everyone was. The walls were paper thin and secrets nonexistent. Mydei had taken to thinking aloud in his head instead, but he'd still wonder if his thoughts were displayed on his face.

"They say it was for a good cause, the say they condemned him as any sinner should." Phainon spoke more calmly now. His face was passive. It had the look of those mindless zombies in that film they'd watched last week.

"Who do you blame?" Mydei asked once the elders had passed.

Phainon's eyes said an entirely different story, but his lips parted and formed the words, "The boy."

And what a pair they made, one silenced and one blinded. One afraid to speak and the other desperately clinging onto the last shreds of their naivety.

The pretense was long since up and here they were, still stuck as unwilling actors in the biggest shitshow of their lives.

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Ten years ago

People with infected brains, people who didn't deserve to share the same place as anyone else, people too absurd and too much of a threat. Mydei had never though he'd be one of them, but here he was. Fourteen and he was convinced a horrible death awaited sinners like him. Everything else seemed so insignificant— tests, assignments, petty arguments. Not when he was going to end up an outcast. That is, if he was one of the lucky ones.

Mydeimos, don't you ever do that to me

Those words still played in his head. He was his mother's son and he wasn't going down without a fight. If he couldn't change his feelings for Phainon, he'd just live with them. He'd weather them out like a winter storm.

Each attempt felt more futile.

Phainon was oblivious to it, but his arm against Mydei's during class made Mydei want to melt into the floor. It was warm— of course it was warm, it would be concerning if it wasn't — but that very observation sent a faint tingle down his spine.

Mydei bit the inside of his mouth, wondering how much further he was going to fall.

A note slid across the table. Phainon was looking anywhere but at him. Mydei eyed him suspiciously but still opened the note.

Want to skip?

Mydei chucked his pen at Phainon. Phainon let out a yelp and rubbed his arm with a wounded expression. It was so akin to a pathetic puppy dog that Mydei found his conviction cracking instantly.

HKS.

Fine.

He scribbled his reply on the paper and slid the paper back to Phainon.

Mydei couldn't have predicted Phainon's plan would be this shoddy. Hiding underneath the bleachers, breaths held, as someone from their class tried to find them.

"You told me you had a plan." Mydei whispered. His legs were beginning to cramp, pins and needles spiking through them.

"I swear I did, okay?" Phainon nervously peeped through a gap, squinting at the bright light that filtered in, "I just didn't account for unforeseen circumstances."

"Those being the teacher noticing we weren't there." Mydei groaned. Why he played along was beyond him, honestly.

Phainon gave him an apologetic look. His lips tilted downward, eyebrows furrowing. Yeah, he'd follow Phainon to the ends of the universe without complaint.

Mydei thought it was all over when their classmate stepped closer to the bleachers. The crunch of her scuffed black shoes drew closer. Mydei clenched his fists, steeling himself for the inevitable aftermath. Next time, *he'd* make the plans. Next time, they'd actually get away with it.

Phainon shifted himself to the front, so that he'd be the only one visible if someone looked behind the bleachers.

"Why are you doing this?" Mydei muttered.

"I'd rather get caught." Phainon said firmly, "Rather me than you."

"I agreed to this." Mydei tugged Phainon back, causing him to briefly lose balance and stagger forward, closer to Mydei.

The determination in his eyes amazed Mydei. "Like I'd ever let you get caught. I swear I won't let you face consequences that were never yours to begin with."

"It's just detention, HKS. Don't act like we're fugitives."

The footsteps receded. Mydei peeked out to see her retreating back. Wasn't that the girl with the braids that said she liked Phainon? She'd even looked pointedly in Phainon's direction as she said it. How something that obvious flew over Phainon's head was impressive. Mydei didn't bother pointing it out, though. He'd reasoned with himself— he didn't need to inflate Phainon's ego or anything. And fine, he was jealous.

Phainon drooped, burying his face in his hands, "Fuck. That was so embarrassing. What was I trying to do? Act like a hero? Forget I said that."

"Don't worry, I'll be there to remind you of it whenever you think you've moved on." Mydei smirked.

Phainon looked positively distraught.

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Nine years ago

At fifteen, Mydei and his father were no different from strangers. He'd come back sometimes to grace them with his presence. Once every few months, if they were lucky. Mydei didn't really care, except for the time Phainon's father helped him fix the garage door because he didn't want to call his mother back from work and disturb her.

He even offered to trim their lawn. Mydei refused at first, but Phainon piped up anyway and insisted that they let his father do it.

"You know that thing they were talking about in class?" Phainon rolled onto his back on Mydei's bed. Mydei laid down beside him, staring pointedly at the ceiling. The buzzing of the cicadas outside filled the room.

Mydei grunted in acknowledgement.

"If a genie granted you three wishes, what would you wish for?" Phainon asked.

"Firstly, why is a genie out here doing charity for us? Is it even trustworthy?" Mydei said shortly.

"Come on, I need *answers*," Phainon shifted to the side, toward Mydei. He could feel Phainon's gaze on the side of his face.

Mydei rested his hands on his stomach. He could feel Phainon's weight pressing down on the bed next to him. In fact, he was acutely aware of it. His throat was dry. "Magic isn't real. So I think it's stupid."

"No, I think it's only because your imagination's so limited. Tell me Mydeimos, are you allergic to joy?"

A shiver ran down his spine when he thought he felt Phainon's breath ghost his shoulder. He screwed his eyes shut, playing it off as frustration. "I'm not allergic, I'm realistic."

Phainon groaned. "Titans, you're such a killjoy."

"I'd wish to leave this town for one." Mydei muttered.

"You'd leave me behind like that? Cold." Phainon shook his head.

"Who's to say you aren't coming with me?"

"I can't." Phainon sounded different now. Pain laced his words, like how he'd described his fall down the porch stairs and its resulting bruises. Phainon was many things, and a good liar was not one of them.

There were strange rumors those days. Rumors that Phainon fought with a kid. As quickly as they started, they were gone. Phainon himself never spoke of them, so it either never happened or he didn't want to acknowledge it.

Mydei pressed his lips together.

His second wish would be for Phainon to come with him.

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Excerpt 3 from the letter

Why won't you reply to me? Is it something I did? I was mad at you at first and that anger caved because how could I be angry at *you*?

Please tell me, if we were born in different bodies and in different lives, could we be together? Could I trace stars on your back and kiss your eyelids and tell you how much I adore you? I think I saw something in your eyes when you held my hand and kissed me and I'm certain it wasn't disgust.

For just a moment, I swear I saw love in your eyes.

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Eight years ago

Despite it all, Phainon never seemed to leave. Mydei was becoming complacent, believing he'd always have Phainon. It just seemed so permanent, so natural, to have this boy in his life that he didn't think about what would happen if he wasn't.

Phainon was now taller than most boys in their class. His smile had gone from sweet to boyishly charming, features sharper and eyelashes annoyingly long. His dimples never left his face, decorating his smiles. He was radiant in every sense of the word.

Everyone noticed, of course. The eyes on him reminded Mydei of his own gaze at Phainon's retreating figure. Some lovestruck, some yearning. The golden boy, the town crush for teenage girls.

Worst of all, he seemed completely oblivious to the attention. Or he did and he didn't really care because his gaze might have been on someone else, but Mydei would rather not imagine that.

He had always been popular, always had an unending supply of people willing to talk to him at the drop of a hat; but he still ended up at Mydei's side. Mydei didn't hate being the first choice. In fact, he thrived off of it.

Mydei had to hold back a snicker at Phainon's blank stare at the heap of pink and red on his table. Roses, cards, chocolates. Mydei reckoned at least twenty girls had heaped their

presents onto the table. Mydei estimated his own table had gifts from four or five. Phainon would like the assorted chocolates.

"Get your stuff off my side." Mydei said, picking up a small teddy bear with the tips of his fingers and precariously placing it on the top of the pile

"What do I do with this?" Phainon asked him like he expected Mydei would know the answer.

Mydei shrugged, opening the box of assorted chocolates. He offered it to Phainon. Phainon gave him a weak noise of thanks and took it.

And wasn't it so funny this was the best he could do to express his feelings? Wasn't it ironic too the very person who dismissed declarations of love during valentines at twelve now wishing he had some way of putting the feelings that screamed in his mind out? Mydei never liked things in half- measures, never liked subtleties. When it came to Phainon, that was all he could afford to do.

The slow, crackling fire of jealousy so vehement he didn't recognise as his own as he passed by that display of valentines chocolates a few days ago returned. Yes, he was jealous. He was terribly jealous of the girls who could be proud of their gifts. The couples who could hold hands and not fear the world. *He* was the flawed one the world was no place for. So why did he yearn for things that would never be his? Forbidden desires, forbidden feelings and all he wanted was to be free.

"If you're not eating any more of that.." Phainon eyed the box in Mydei's hands.

Mydei was all too eager to hand him the box. "Take it. It's yours."

Phainon shot him a smile and went back to trying to disassemble the tower of gifts. "Really," he muttered, "you'd think I was some celebrity from the gifts I'm getting."

"Probably are." Mydei shrugged.

Some of their classmates eyed Phainon's pile of gifts with fascination. Phainon was all too eager to dump it all in the hands of som unsuspecting person. One wide smile and that was all it took for the desk to be cleared out. The power he had; Phainon had no idea.

"But that's just cause of the temple." Phainon slumped back onto his seat.

Mydei shot him a withering glare. "Pardon?"

"I mean, I'm the most likely to become the next head priest, right?"

"I really don't think that applies here." Mydei didn't know if he should pity Phainon's admirers or be happy Phainon was this dumb sometimes.

"But it does." Phainon insisted, "They've always loved me."

That part was admittedly true. But the way Phainon said it, with such a hollow smile, was what made Mydei stop in his tracks. Anyone would be happy for all that attention. Not Phainon. He looked like he wanted to shrink because of it. Like it was meant for some other person and not him.

Mydei would comfort him, but he had no idea how to. "So you don't like the attention, then."

"Would they still like me if I wasn't their golden boy? If I was—" Phainon cut himself off, exhaling sharply. "—never mind."

Mydei knew better than to pry. Phainon morosely stuffed three chocolates into his mouth and chewed slowly. As Mydei reached out for a chocolate himself, Phainon batted his hand away.

"HKS, I gave you that." Mydei glared at him.

Phainon grinned at him with the force of a thousand suns. "Mine now."

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Six years ago

Phainon no longer went to the temple. There was a haunted look behind his eyes that never left. Mydei feared what he'd say if asked, so he never did. The scabs on his hand remained. It looked an awful lot like finger-nail marks.

Mydei pressed the horn. Once. Twice.

Phainon was running out the door, in shorts and a white shirt. It clung to his chest, Mydei's brain supplied unhelpfully. he let his eyes wander for a second before snapping them away.

"Where to today?" Mydei asked.

"Anywhere." Phainon sank into the car seat, letting out a tired exhale and closing his eyes. His hair was mussed. Resisting the urge to run his hands through it, Mydei tapped the steering wheel.

"How about we drive through town?"

"That works."

"Hold on, let me just—" Mydei leaned to the side to adjust the rear view mirror. Out of the corner of his eye, he could swear Phainon was looking at him with a foreign, wide- eyed expression. It was gone when Mydei faced him. His cheeks remained flushed.

Mydei's stomach writhed as he pulled back and switched on the ignition.

The engine came alive with a hum. Mydei wet his lips with his tongue.

The town was relatively quiet that day. Or maybe it was because it was midday. Phainon was silent— he was more subdued lately— as he watched the town go by.

The inside of the car felt sweltering. Mydei wheeled down the window, humid air whipping their hair. Phainon did the same. The wind stung his eyes.

For a few minutes, they were barrelling down empty roads. For a few minutes, they were free. No other thought existed in Mydei's head, the outside world just passing them by. If this was what feeling high was like, Mydei would want it every second of his life.

Mydei had to slow down as they reached the marketplace. A group of people, all dressed in white linen. That's why there was no one out on the streets. Someone was being dragged in the front, arms held up, backs of their heels hit by the people that constrained them.

Someone was being condemned that day. And that someone may not make it out alive.

Mydei gripped the steering wheel until his knuckles whitened and his palms buzzed. Phainon was stock- still beside him. Venom. Pure venom in Phainon's eyes as he watched the procession up to the temple. The air around him felt like ice. His eyes were always gentle, always upturned. Now, they resembled someone Mydei didn't know existed. What had the temple done to him?

Mydei restarted the engine. "Do you want to leave?"

"Yes." Phainon said quickly.

"How about we drive in that road by the sea?" Phainon added.

Leaving the town, he drove down winding roads. (*he'd leave not long after, but he let himself childishly imagine it was them escaping together*)

The forested roads turned into paved, hillside ones an hour into the drive. Int he meantime, Phainon had found a channel on the radio that played loud rock music.

("This one reminds me of you" He said.

"Why'd you think that?"

Phainon had smiled, "I don't need to have a reason because I just do. Know someone long enough and you'll start finding them in little things.")

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Present day

Mydei saw Phainon in the summer skies. Except, the blue in his eyes was prettier. Phainon was there in every cheap pack of cigarettes he'd sometimes sneak past his father. Phainon was every secret he heard and memorise for future reference instinctively only to realise there was no one to tell them to.(*they were worthless now; nobody ever got as close to him as Phainon did. That man held his heart in the palm of his hand— that's how close he was.*)

Phainon was the odd coldness at his side, like there was always meant to be someone there. Phainon was the childhood he mourned. Phainon was in the vinyls at a nearby record store he'd frequent.

Loved a boy once, broke my heart.

Cruel boy of my teenage years

What if you loved me?

I miss you, come back

Mydei had stopped short when he'd seen those tracks. The world stopped moving around him. Then the attendant eyed him curiously and he shoved his hands into his pockets and walked to another corner of the store. He could have sworn he could see Phainon staring back at him instead of the people on the covers, almost resentful.

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Six years ago

The sea came into view, green- blue water and flecks of sunlight dancing along waves. Phainon leaned out of the car window, enthralled. The sea was beautiful when it wasn't raging. Seagulls called from high above them, white darts in the sky.

Phainon got out of the car and climbed onto a rock. Steadying himself, he slowly raised his head and watched the thrashing waves. Mydei followed suit. They climbed down the rocks, leaping across them, sometimes slipping on one.

Finally, they reached the rocks closest to the water. In particularly bad storms, water would engulf them entirely. This place was nearly unapproachable in any other kind of weather but the sea was much tamer that day. Phainon climbed onto the largest rock, eroded from the relentless tide.

Slowly, he raised his arms as the salty air whipped his white hair. His shoulders slumped. It was like he was calling out to embrace the sea, embrace the cruel tides and the summer skies. His untied shoelaces picked up with the wind and fluttered.

Mydei sat on the same rock, right beside him. The waves sprayed bits of water onto them in tiny droplets.

"Is this all there is to life? To grow old and die?" Phainon seemed to be asking no one at all.

Mydei took off his shoes and socks and placed them beside him. "I mean, in hindsight, isn't it reality? Everyone dies someday."

"But do we really have to make ourselves that miserable before we do? Why do we deem some things right and some things wrong and why do people have to pay the price for it? Why do we make people kill themselves over it?" Phainon's voice cracked at the last part. They were thinking about the same people— Lydia's roommate, the upperclassman and all those who were forgotten in the unforgiving sea.

He wondered if there were still undiscovered bodies floating around in those cerulean depths. The scavengers might have gotten to them, stripping off chunks of flesh from bone. He wondered if they regretted it in their last second before they took the jump.

"It's irrational. They fear what they don't understand." One hand shielding his eyes, Mydei looked up at Phainon. "They fear death, so they believe their fates are in the hands of gods."

Phainon's gaze was focused on the sun above them, as if in a staring contest with it. "They fear the unknown."

Mydei didn't know what Phainon got out of staring at the sun till his eyes burned.

Phainon's hair whipped about in the wind. The sun cast a halo around him, making him appear almost iridescent. If he said he was a god, Mydei would believe him without question. "And isn't it so funny that everything ends up meaningless? All that terror, all that fear. Sometimes, I wonder what I'd be if I wasn't so scared."

"Of them." Mydei sighed.

"Of everything. I feel like there's so much I never got to have because of this *fear* and it burns me to think I never will."

Phainon was looking directly at him when he said that.

(Not now. Please, not now. A voice in his head pleaded, *please don't mean me and don't mean us. It's impossible, like the sun ever meeting the moon.*)

"You haven't been going to the temple lately. Does what happened earlier have something to do with it? You've been sadder lately." Mydei attempted to be casual about it so as to not make Phainon clam up. He always had a habit of refusing to let up when something was wrong.

"I hate the temple." Phainon said bluntly.

Mydei had never dreamed Phainon would ever say those words. "You're being serious."

"Dead serious." Phainon finally looked at him. He wore a wan smile.

"Shit."

"I hate it so fucking much." Phainon hissed, kicking nothing but stray grains of sand off the rock. "I hate those sermons, I hate the way they are and I hate the head priest. I hate the people, I hate the slab of marble, I hate what they call worship. It's mindless obedience they call devotion."

The gulls and Mydei were the only witnesses to his outburst. Maybe that's why he was having it in the first place.

"Fuck that temple, fuck everyone here, fuck it all!" Phainon yelled out loud, his voice largely drowned out by the roar of the tides. He breathed heavily,

A long pause.

"Didn't know you had that in you." Mydei finally said.

Phainon bent over, laughing breathlessly, "Me neither."

"What, gonna curse *me* out next?"

"Fucker." Phainon kicked the side of Mydei's leg. Mydei inched away, disgruntled.

"You're going to slip and fall." Mydei leaned back, the sun- warmed rock burning his palms.

"You'd never let that happen to me." Phainon joked.

True, but he'd rather fall face first into the water himself than admit it.

A particularly tall wave splashed water onto the bottom of his jeans, soaking them completely. Mydei groaned and rolled them up to his knees, pulling his knees in.

This summer felt ripped out of one of those movies his mother had bought for him. Warm, sultry heat, sea- salt air, sand in their jeans as they got back under the veil of night.

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Excerpt 4 from the letter

Why does the flame burn so incandescently? Why does the moth willingly burn to ashes within it? Is love death or does love mean so much that death is a small price to pay?

I read these words in a book and they have stuck with me since. It was a book from the bygone era, from the great Kremnoan library. Ironic, because it burned down. I hope it burnt in the face of its creator's lover.

I used to call it childish and unnecessarily cruel to face such a fate all for love.

And then there was you.

When I read it for the second time, I finally understood. Your eyes on mine, I have never had such a gentle gaze on me. It was so tender, but felt like the force of a wildfire. Yes, I would burn in that flame. Call it foolish, but aren't we all fools when we fall in love?

I think I will die still loving you. I think death is not a sacrifice people make for love, but to carry love to one's death must mean that love is stronger than death itself. Love lasts, see. It will not just die with the person, it will remain in the ways that person expressed it. It will be in letters, in the other person's heart, everything. Love stories outlive their actors.

To love and to be loved is a thirst we are born with. Each soul is searching; eternally hungry for it. If to love is to be human, why must my love be condemned so? If love is pure, why is mine impure?

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Six years ago

This time, Eurypon *was* home. Mydei brushed the reeds of grass out of his hair as subtly as he could manage.

"Where were you?"

"Out." Mydei said curtly.

"With that *boy*, I assume." Eurypon had a look of distaste on his face.

Mydei grit his teeth. The lightness in his chest had burst. Whatever joy he had from being around Phainon was gone in an instant. Burst like a balloon. That man was barely ever home and each time, he brought with him thunderclouds. "Yeah, what of it?"

Eurypon raised his hands in surrender. It wasn't an actual show of him backing down— it was more of a taunt. "Nothing."

"Why're you home?"

Eurypon stood up. Mydei was now taller than him by nearly four inches. He cleared his throat and took a step forward. "As you know, our business—"

"—your business—"

"— the *family* business. Do not interrupt me, Mydeimos." Eurypon reprimanded, deep lines etched into his frowning face. "Our business has been flourishing as of late. For stability, we will need support. Therefore, you are to be engaged and wed to the heiress of our partnering company."

Mydei didn't hear the words at first, still seething. Then, it hit him all at once.

"No." he said immediately.

"Yes." Eurypon sounded almost bored. Like he expected Mydei to cave anyways. Mydei knew he ought to. He knew he should bend his head and accept.

Mydei shook his head disbelievingly. "What part of that didn't you get?"

"You will be married. By this winter." Eurypon said firmly.

"I don't want to!" Mydei protested.

Eurypon scoffed, clearly not taking Mydei seriously. "Well, why not?"

"I— I just—" Mydei always knew what to say. Just not this time.

Talking to Eurypon was like ramming himself into a brick wall. It didn't budge, glaring back at him condescendingly. He felt so fucking stupid for talking back. So fucking small and weak in ways he despised. He wanted nothing more to dig his nails into that man's shoulders and shake him until he finally understood.

Eurypon arched an eyebrow and Mydei had never wished he wasn't his father's son this badly before.

Mydei finally got the words out. Pathetic how he tried to mimic the authority in Eurypon's voice. Even more so that he thought it would work. "I refuse to. I will never marry anyone not of my choosing."

"You're being obstinate."

He'd always been mature for his age, always the one they could rely on. but couldn't he just act his age for once? Couldn't he fight back and have himself heard? Fine, he'd admit it— he was immature, he was irrational and he didn't want to be with anyone on this planet if it wasn't Phainon.

"Don't tell me you're in *love* with someone, Mydeimos." Eurypon looked at him as though that was a minor inconvenience.

"None of your business!" Mydei snapped.

If, even after all this time, he couldn't muster the guts to tell his own mother about it— it was near impossible to tell his father. Gorgo might not get mad at him, but she'd never be able to look at him the same way again. Eurypon would demand he fix himself. Titans above, he'd disown Mydei. There was always that small voice that told him his father did care, but when staring into those hollow eyes, Mydei found it hard to believe. Those were cold eyes that would not care if the sinner was his own flesh and blood.

Blood was just the rope that tied them together, the two hanging men, and it could just as easily be severed.

"She is a wonderful young girl." Eurypon added, completely unprompted.

And Phainon was the most wonderful person Mydei had ever known— his sun, his anchor, his warm fire. But that didn't matter, did it? Just because it was a man.

Mydei had a sudden mental image of his future. They'd live in tandem, two dolls in an opulently decorated dollhouse. He'd never be happy again. He doubted the girl would be either. "I won't marry her."

"Mydeimos, I am not *offering* you anything. This is your duty."

"Even then, I will refuse."

Mydei didn't hear the door swing open or the footsteps. Instead, he felt a hand on his shoulder.

"Gorgo, tell your son he needs to grow up." Eurypon demanded.

"*Grow up?*" Mydei was beginning to sound hysteric, "What's left for me to grow up into? I've *been* grown up for years! I've been perfectly mature and *now* you tell me to grow up? Here's the thing— I can't. I can't give you any more. I did everything you ever wanted me to do and I can't give you the rest of my life too."

Eurypon looked positively livid. In the back of his mind, Mydei wondered if he too looked that way in Hyperion's eyes. He hoped he didn't. He hoped he didn't have his father's temper.

"*You*—" Eurypon's voice spelled danger

Gorgo stalked forward, cornering Eurypon. "What is the meaning of this?"

"You agreed to it." Eurypon gestured wildly at Mydei.

"Only when he turns twenty five."

Mydei felt like he was underwater, where none of his words mattered. He could be drowning for all they cared.

"Mother, you cannot expect me to do that."

"Mydeimos, I am so sorry—"

"—*mother*." Mydei was chewing the inside of his mouth now. Was he just imagining the tang of blood or was it actually there? Reality sat heavy in his throat. His legs were locked into place; there was no way he could run. How valuable could this deal be that even his mother couldn't stop it? Was he asking for too much— wanting her to put an end to it all? (*when he*

was much younger, he would hide behind his mother and squeeze his eyes shut because nothing could ever reach him there. she was a shield that could protect him from the outside world. no place was ever that safe)

Gorgo closed her eyes, like this hurt her too. "You might learn to get used to it. You don't have to love each other. You can live away from her. I truly want the best for you"

"Why aren't you stopping this then?" Mydei snapped.

Silence. For a few, fragile seconds, nobody moved.

"It is your duty. I expect you to follow through." Eurypon broke the silence.

"Fuck duty! Fuck it all! Am I not your *son*? If you wanted a toy you could wed off and drag around, why did you ever have me? Do you even love *me* or do you love me because I am your son?"

Eurypon seemed at a loss for words. Perhaps for the first time in his life. Mydei stalked upstairs. Deep in his heart, he knew the engagement was set. He could bite like a cornered animal, fight like a mangy dog in the ring and he was still powerless. The hand would still land, the fate still shackle him.

He was powerless and bitter and vengeful and not at all like the loving son Gorgo had raised. Was this who he was always going to end up as or did something go wrong along the way?

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Six years ago- the day before the end

He watched Phainon's house from his window for a long time. The taste of Phainon's lips and cigarette smoke still ghosted his tongue. He could swear he smelled it in the air still. The sunset felt different. Phainon's house was illuminated in a nostalgic glow. Like childhood. He

wanted his youth back. He wanted his heart back. It was already breaking into small, unsalvageable pieces.

"Hey." Gorgo stepped into his room, shutting the door behind her.

Mydei hadn't talked to either of his parents since that day, always sneaking in through his bedroom window. They either hoped he'd come around or decided to give him space.

"Hi." Mydei moved aside to give her space to sit.

"What's wrong? You've been off lately."

"Guess." Mydei said drily.

Gorgo sighed deeply. "I know you're angry because of the engagement. You're also sad because of something else"

Phainon. At the end of the day, always him.

"No reason." Mydei shrugged, "How did the engagement even come to be?"

If she knew he was avoiding the topic, she didn't question it. "It was for the best"

"You got engaged to father and you know how *that's* going."

"I loved him at first." Gorgo had an undecipherable expression on her face.

Mydei blinked, surprised. "And now?"

She only smiled.

"I won't be happy there. I never will be." Mydei knew his protests wouldn't change a thing.

"I'm trying to annul it." Gorgo said, voice steady.

Mydei bit back his words.

Then try harder

Instead, he nodded slowly. "I'm never getting married."

"Because?" She nudged him on.

What was the point if it wasn't Phainon he was getting married to?

He wished he could tell her. Years worth of secrets held so close to his heart they'd left a mark on it would come tumbling out. And then she'd look at him in disgust. There was no going back to being her beloved son after that.

Mydei drew his curtains shut. "There's no point."

"Is that a letter?" Gorgo gestured to the folded up piece of paper on the desk.

"Phainon's leaving." Mydei said shortly. It felt like a punch to gut once he said it, all the air leaving his lungs.

Understanding flickered across her face.

"He's— well," Mydei sighed," It feels like it's over, you know? My childhood. I'm not ready to say goodbye to it."

"I'm so sorry, little lion. I truly am." She patted his hair softly.

Mydei found himself leaning into it. The yellow light of the lamp soon became the only source of light in his room. Gorgo got up after a while, hugging him tightly before shutting the door behind her.

Making his way to his desk and to the letter, he unfolded it again. It was beginning to form creases from the number of times he'd unfolded and folded it. He traced the words on the letter, wondering if they could carry his feelings too. They had to.

If he could redo all of this, he'd befriend and fall in love with Phainon all over again. Fuck it all, fuck the ending. (*he accepted he'd never have a happy ending long ago*). Phainon was worth it.

He'd almost said it yesterday.

(His face was still flushed after splashing water on it. His heart hammered, knees weak. Phainon kissed him. Phainon kissed him. It was something out of his wildest fantasies. Unreal. Phainon was unreal. Did he know that? He had the sun for a soul and the heavens for eyes.

And almost immediately, the regret had hit him. He could have taken the jump, taken the risk.)

The words were there. They were lodged in the back of his throat.

I love you and I think you might love me too.

Nothing came out. Of course he wouldn't have the guts to say it.

Mydei hated feeling so unsure of himself.

But when Phainon looked at him like *that*, with those gentle eyes, all coherent thought failed him.

He set the letter down. Tomorrow. Tomorrow, he'd give it to Phainon. And Phainon would read it someday. Mydei had never wanted to become a memory, but he'd resigned himself to that fate. If he was going to be a memory, he'd like for himself to be the best memory Phainon ever had.

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Six years ago, the aftermath

No, that couldn't be possible. Mydei had been out there since eight. Surely, he wouldn't miss such a tall guy leaving his house through the only exit. Surely Phainon would want to talk to him. That guy even cried when saying goodbye. He wouldn't flake on Mydei like this, right?

He clutched the letter in his hands, crumpling it. Phainon would be here any moment now. Rain pattered onto the pavement. His shirt clung uncomfortably, soaking wet.

But noon turned to evening and evening turned to night. Phainon had left without telling Mydei.

So here Mydei was, waiting for him like a fool, his heart poured into that stupid fucking letter. He'd confessed everything there. How stupidly in love he'd been for who knows how long. Maybe he'd always been in love, maybe love had crept up on him like a slow, blooming vine. It was really just that easy to love Phainon. So effortless that it was terrifying. If he didn't know how wrong this was, he would have called it fate.

Fate was cruel, though. It held all he had ever wanted out of reach.

Out of sheer spite, he didn't write a single letter. His resolve lasted for approximately one week. He sent letters almost religiously after that. The people at the post office had memorised his face by then.

Every time he left his own house, he would catch sight of Phainon's empty house and wonder where all the time had gone. He should have spent it better. There were a million things he'd have liked to do differently and all of them had slipped past his fingers.

If a genie existed that granted you three wishes, what would you wish for?

Mydei knew then that he would use up all three of his wishes to get his best friend back.

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The salvageable lines of the confession letter

…

I like you. No, like doesn't seem enough for this. It's love.

…

Wait for me.

…

I am a prideful man and I hate hiding away a part of myself. It's dishonest, but it's survival. Why was fear the first thing they taught us?

…

I wish we were born in a world where I could feel what I do for you without feeling ashamed.

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Five years ago

The day before he had to meet his future wife, Mydei stormed into his father's office. He'd been living in Kremnos for the past week now.

Eurypon jumped, not expecting Mydei to be there. Mydei had made it clear he wasn't interested in so much as looking his way. He'd avoided him like the plague and Eurypon didn't seem to care. They truly were nothing more than strangers in the same house.

"Revoke it." Mydei demanded.

Eurypon rubbed a tired hand over his face. "You know I can't—"

"—or I leave this company. Find yourself another heir."

Eurypon looked visibly rattled. "Mydeimos, this isn't like you. You were never this… *unruly*."

"It *is* me," Mydei slammed a hand on Eurypon's desk, almost relishing the sharp pain of the splinter that dug into his palm."But you just never cared enough to know me."

"How could you say that to your own father?" Eurypon scoffed, affronted. He stood up, his chair creaking violently.

Mydei laughed bitterly. "Do you think you can even call yourself a father?"

"I have done everything for you—" Eurypon gestured to his office, "This company was for *you* to inherit. Everything I did was for the sake of this family. I will not tolerate such disrespect. Do you hear me?"

Mydei scanned his father's eyes. He had a vague memory of those eyes looking down at him, kind and warm. (*A park. They were in a park of some sort and Eurypon was holding his tiny hand. It was probably a memory from way back then, when Mydei was three or four. Before they moved to a new town. His life must have been good back then because it was the kind of memory that made a lump form in this throat. He did have it once, just not now. Eurypon must have hugged him then. When was the last time his father hugged him?*)

Finally, he said quietly, "No, my mother was the only one who raised me. She did it all by herself. You were nothing at all."

Eurypon went silent. That had done it.

Was that *guilt* on his face?

"If you ever had a shred of affection for me in you heart, annul it." Mydei said before shutting the door.

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The engagement was dissolved. Mydei never had to meet her. Good. He knew he wouldn't be able to stomach that.

"So," Eurypon set his fork down. Mydei was seconds away from springing out of his seat and making a run for it. Eurypon seemed to be trying to make amends now. Mydei wanted to fight harder, demand he feel more guilt. There was only so much he could demand; nothing would ever sate him. After all, forgiveness wouldn't amend all those years, fix that chasm between them.

Mydei eyed him warily.

"Who's this object of your affections?" He was sure Eurypon didn't mean to sound this condescending, but he still bristled at that.

"None of your business."

And yet he still prodded. "Anyone we know?"

Mydei scowled heavily.

"It's over. No point."

"Were you happy?"

Happy? *Happy* didn't even begin to describe the joy Phainon brought to his life. Happy was a gross underestimation of it. He made the world lighter, the skies brighter. He made Mydei's life better by just being in it. Lydia's words came back to his head, blurred by time but just as clear, *A lot of people would do anything for a close companion like that.*

Nobody ever talked about how it felt to lose them. Nobody talked about the hollowness that followed, like a part of his heart had been carved right out.

Mydei aimlessly stabbed the vegetables on his plate. "You have no idea."

His feigned nonchalance did nothing to hide the crack in his voice.

Eurypon looked regretful— and he had no right to. None at all. This was Mydei's heartbreak. His to bear. Mydei's foot tapped against the floor in a restless rhythm. Titans, if only he could just leave.

And as if just to rub salt into the wound, Eurypon said, "She must've been something, huh?"

He was. He truly was.

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Excerpt 5 from the letter

I am well aware that the way I feel for you isn't right. So tell me— why does it have to feel so right? Why did you slip back into my life like you hadn't been missing from it for an agonisingly long time? Why did I let you? It was like you erased all my heartbreak and then did worse upon me— and I let you. Every single time.

In every single life, I would let you.

It's pathetic, really, the things I would do for you. Name it, give me the smallest of smiles in return, and I would. I would only because it's you and I think you might do the same.

Please love me next time. I will never know if you loved me now, but please fall in love with me if we are ever reborn. I will find you and all I can ask is for you to love me back. I felt what it was like to be loved by you for minutes. I want to know what it's like to be loved by you for a lifetime.

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Present day— the summer he saw him again

Mydei felt all the air leave his lungs when he saw him again. Phainon was at the doorstep. Phainon was in front of him and *real* and not some figment of his imagination. There was a faint tinkly feeling of wonder. Like the flighty crush he had as a kid. Love like he had as a teenager. A first love reignited, even though the feelings had never faded.

Phainon was more or less the same. Except he'd grown into his features some more and his eyes had sharpened by the smallest fraction. Enough to no longer resemble the wide, kind eyes he used to have. His gaze was mellowed out. His hair was kept a little longer, snow white strands brushing just above his eyes. He walked with a newfound confidence, his head held high. Any manner of things could have happened in those six years. Whatever it was, Phainon was different now. The town was worse than before and it didn't seem to affect him. He'd moved on.

Mydei sometimes felt like he was the only one who still refused to move on. If he had moved on, he'd no longer find any need to return to his old house every summer. He'd have abandoned all hope of seeing Phainon again. As if the universe decided to stop playing cruel jokes on him, it gave him Phainon.

He had him. He finally had him and now Phainon was completely out of reach. A distant sun, his once more. His to admire for those fleeting days. His to memorise until the curve of Phainon's lips and the faint crow's feet at the corners of his eyes when he laughed especially hard were permanently etched into Mydei's mind once more. His to remember. Never his to keep.

At least he got to say goodbye properly this time around. He tried to keep himself sated from that alone. Starving men can feed off scraps just fine.

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Final excerpt from the letter

I sent you my number, I sent you my new address, what more do you want from me? My heart is already yours, so there's nothing else I can offer up now.

I don't think I have the strength to write you a letter after this, so let it be known this is the last time I will try. Two years. For approximately seven hundred and thirty days since the day

we parted ways, I have thought of you in each one of them. I have written to you ninety times. Nearly once every single week. And each time, I spent weeks agonising over what I'd say the next time. Someone once looked at me scribbling a letter down on my notepad in the office and asked me if I planned to become a writer with all the things I kept writing. Maybe I could, for I have certainly amassed enough words over all the letters to write out a a novel and then some.

This is also the last time I will ever write about my feelings to you. Don't think I'm letting go of my feelings because believe me, I have tried and failed for I will never get over you. Just think of it as me waving my white flag in surrender. I give up.

I lost you.

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Present day

Mydei and Gorgo sat at the dining table in his apartment. She peeled an apple with a knife, its skin curling around it and falling in spirals. One long, continuous peel finally cascaded to the tabletop. The tablecloth was the checkered one she'd brought him as a gift. It reminded Mydei of beaches. He liked it a lot.

She picked up another one from the basket of fruits. He'd stocked up on quite a few fruits. It was summer and watermelons were aplenty. He bought them repeatedly because he liked the taste and not because it reminded him of the summer he was eighteen.

The sharp, tart smell of apples filled the air. A quiet evening— the first in months since he took over his father's role. Mydei absentmindedly cut the pears into little cubes. His mind was far off, bundled up in some safe place where he could daydream freely.

"You've been different since last summer." She said, picking out the stem of the apple, "Even more so since the past month."

An observation that demanded an answer. There was no denying the concern in her voice. Mydei bit the inside of his mouth. That question was bound to come at some point. What could he tell her, anyway? Tell her why he was so adamant on visiting their old town every summer in hopes of finding *him* there? Tell her about the last time that happened?

"Nothing." Mydei shrugged.

"I heard about the police's involvement and the killers." Gorgo said plainly.

"So why're you asking me this?" Visions of the man he'd killed flashed before his eyes right on cue. Nobody knew it was him back then and nobody knew even now. He still saw it. He still felt the plunge of the knife. He still felt the resounding lack of guilt because it was *Phainon* that man was trying to kill and nobody was ever allowed to lay a hand on Phainon.

He would've done it again. Again and again and as many times he'd have to for Phainon.

Gorgo eyed him sternly. "I'm your mother, little lion. I know when something's wrong. And I can tell it wasn't about the deaths."

Mydei decided it was the right time to pretend like the tablecloth was the most fascinating thing he'd ever seen.

She shook her head as if disappointed, her hand moving steady as she "You go through these periodic cycles of what I can only describe as mourning. Every single year. Now, you're somehow worse off."

Gorgo had asked him time and time again what was wrong. Each time, he'd chalked it up to nostalgia. Each time, she'd pretended to buy his lies knowing full well he had no emotional attachment to that town.

"I went there for the last time. Whatever business I had there is over, so you don't have to worry about me." Mydei reached for the first peeled apple and began to cut it, shoving the

sliced pear aside.

"It's heartbreak, isn't it?" She said, setting the second peeled apple down.

He offered her a small smile, a twitch of his lips into what might look like an apologetic smile.

He'd never recover from it, no matter how many summers he lived through. The summer sun would only ever be cruel now. He still despised it.

Yes, it was heartbreak. Heartbreak of the worst kind.

End Notes

And that marks the end of this storyline! I hope you liked this silly little idea that's been slow cooking in my head for a few months now. I have a few other fic ideas I want to get to, so I hope I see you guys soon<33

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!